

## Shari Jeanine Aubrey

Another joyous, short-haired woman in my family

I always had glimpses of her. I think I was jealous even then of the time my sisters & cousins got with her, while I was so many years younger.

Shari Jeanine Aubrey... Whose face lights up when I sing, as she pours love into me teaching me songs to sing with confidence

We, the children of the church, are important players in an excellent show. We work together to review the bonus lyrics she's taught for Rudolph the Red-Nosed Reindeer, just before stepping on stage in Bethany Hall. We find Shari's beaming face & precise directors hands before us

"A Tale of 3 Trees" comes next, at Easter. We workshop the scenes: the tree that made the manger, the tree that made the boat, the tree that made the cross.

My family moves far away, I listen to CDs of church shows I know she directed with my cousins & I long to be there with her.

I go to church camp in Carlsbad, at Black River. She picks me up after the van ride home & we sit in Grammie's tiny pink backyard.

Her smile radiates, I'm the only person who matters. "What did you do?, what did you sing?," she asks. "Ah yes, the boys did that" & "what about this song?"

I'm surrounded by pink & packing in Grammie's king-sized bed that night. I've found out somehow that Shari smokes cigarettes & I am scared & sad. Could she get sick? And why did she who seems to give her everything to me hide this thing?

We go together to Angel Fire & sit at the cabin. My cousins & sisters aren't there, so I get Shari to myself. We put the *Wicked* original Broadway cast album on for her & I tell her the story I've heard from my sister. We enter it, we marvel at it. I just want to be music with her.

10 years later, I sing here at Monte Vista with my dad. Shari tells me my voice has matured, & I have a beautiful soprano. My dad had made some mistakes in the harmony, but she just shrugs. Risking messy notes is the way to learn more. My

parents & Bob & Shari pull out tough music to sightread & try. They seem to have made this a practice. I'm in awe, I want to too.

"let your light shine before others," Jesus said, "so that they may see your good works and give glory to God. People do not light a lamp and put it under the bushel basket; rather, they put it on the lampstand, and it gives light to all in the house." Matthew 5

Many years later, we are singing karaoke on a family vacation & my husband is coming to know the music among us. He asks what songs Shari might remember, & if we might play them. Perhaps the duet classics of she & my mom's. Perhaps the duet classic, symbolic even, to she & Bob. He stands up & begins, easing into beautiful vocals. Her back straightens & she grows in strength, she comes in right on cue. She prepares & carries the high notes & long phrases. The music is in her, she is the music, they are connected through it, and them to all of us.

and then she is back from the Alzheimer's for a glorious period. She looks me in the eyes & says "that's my girl" and I know I am as I have so wanted to be, which is her girl. I laugh that, indeed, I had been up front keeping the family on tempo, giving the cues, jumping about & directing with much joy; and natural passion that I get from her. She taught me how to do it & she loves & sees me now. She sees her grandchildren & oohs & ahs at their voices. and sometimes she sings the note more on tune, to teach us. We become one with her & the music.

While sometimes we might say "oh, she could have been a star..." she said "I know I am, and I shine wherever I am, to the people I love, in the community where I'm part." Thank you, Shari, for all you gave us & this community in music & love. I think you found abundance, joy, & connection there, thanks be to God, and I am so grateful for your passion & light.

Love, Rachel